

BOOK REVIEW

Becoming Boundless: Indian Transnational Entrepreneurs in the Global Economy

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Manashi Ray's *Becoming Boundless: Indian Transnational Entrepreneurs in the Global Economy* is an important contribution to the study of diaspora engagement, migrant entrepreneurship, migration and development, network theory, and transnational businesses. The book focuses on transnational entrepreneurs (TEs), defined as “businesspeople who engage in economic activities, particularly between the United States and India” (5). The overarching questions the book seeks to answer are why Indian migrants become transnational entrepreneurs, why some of them return to India, and what determines their success or failure. To explore these questions, Ray examines differences between women and men and the specific role of caste structures, as well as economic and noneconomic factors, including the importance of transnational and other networks.

The book is based on semi-structured interviews with 60 Indian TEs, 45 of whom are men and 15 women. Though the author has conducted a limited number of follow-up interviews until 2021, the bulk of the data comes from one-time interviews conducted between 2007 and 2018. Her diverse group of participants includes first and multigenerational entrepreneurs in technology, manufacturing, green energy, bioeconomy, and professional services.

1 | Holistic Assessment of Decision-Making Process

A strength of the book's analysis is the holistic examination of decision-making processes that considers economic and non-economic factors, both at the micro and macro level. Ray highlights TEs' human, cultural, economic, and social capital, their upbringing and pre-migration context, as well as how visa uncertainty and limited work authorization shape entrepreneurial

and return decisions. Other noneconomic factors in her analysis are spouse/partner relationships, close and extended family networks, community/caste, and nationalistic aspirations. On the other hand, the book assesses the impact of economic forces for return and transnational entrepreneurship—namely, the 2001 recession, the 2008 global economic crisis, as well as India's economic development and specific policies, such as the “Make in India” program.

Ray observes a facilitating role of the Overseas Citizenship of India (OCI)—a special diaspora citizenship regime (Naujoks 2013)—for transnational entrepreneurship, although the details and categorization of this membership policy are not adequately reflected in the book.¹

2 | TEs' Use of Networks

A particular focus of Ray's inquiry lies on the role of transnational networks for setting up, scaling, and succeeding in transnational entrepreneurship. Transnational networks are often taken for granted, with little attention “to how post-migration transnational networks actually emerge, expand, and are used for cross-border entrepreneurial practices” (191). Drawing on Faist (2012) and other transnational scholars, Ray highlights the role and creation of transnational social spaces between India and the US, in which information, knowledge, and capital flow.

“[T]o understand the complexities of transnational entrepreneurship, one must consider both the personal and public life of TEs, as Indian TEs typically belong to closely knit groups of actors, like immediate or extended or multigenerational families, linguistic or regional communities, and faith-based organizations that facilitate building ‘trust’ and strong ties” (86). In

several parts of the book Ray shows that kinship relations and caste networks are critical variables in the economic pursuits of many of her participants, especially for TEs from traditional mercantile families. On the other hand, she emphasizes that in some cases, Indian TEs consciously overcome limitations of family networks by hiring outside experts to professionalize family businesses. Similarly, she observes that in some areas, digital communities have replaced the value of traditional and caste networks (189).

In the context of return migration, Ray finds that “the maturation of a range of global networks (high school, college, caste/community, industry, and trade) eased returnee entrepreneurs’ transitions to India” (145). Overall, she finds a particularly strong impact of alumni networks from Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) and the collective alumni association PanIIT.

Ray rightly critiques the limited power of scholarship on ethnic entrepreneurship to explain and theorize successful companies by immigrants outside ethnic enclaves, and particularly of migrants’ transnational businesses (11). Notably, Ray’s participants do not exclusively rely on co-ethnics for their business pursuits.

3 | Returnee Entrepreneurship

Becoming Boundless’ third chapter focuses on returnees’ entrepreneurial activities. Ray highlights that the decision to return is “rarely linear because life is messy [...] and] the conditions that facilitated the decisions for reverse migration [...] are highly context- and place-specific” (106). “The decision to relocate was often precipitated by life-changing incidents, like the unexpected death or illness of a family member, the spouse’s career prospects, family inheritance and responsibilities, community obligations, or optimum mobilization of financial and social resources for business opportunities” (111).

Ray observes four major motivations for return: adding value to family businesses, cultivating “care” in family life, rearticulating the meaning of power and time, and participating in India’s growth story. In fact, care-giving (for parents) or care-receiving (for children) activities are the top two reasons for returning. Confirming findings from Naujoks (2013) (p. 339), Ray highlights the importance of TEs’ life stage for return and entrepreneurial decisions, especially the age and school-related aspects of their children.

4 | Intersectionality and Women TEs

Of the three substantive chapters of the book, Chapters 2 and 3 focus on Ray’s male participants and Chapter 4 on women TEs. The specific focus on gender-differentiated pathways, experiences, and outcomes highlights important differences in how women engage in cross-border ventures, compared to men. Women’s entrepreneurial outcomes are “more deeply facilitated and influenced by societal and institutional support, like marital status, inheritance, benevolent family structure, and religious affiliation” (195). And her female participants are more engaged in professional services. Showcasing the heterogeneity of Indian

TEs, in addition to high-flyer Silicon Valley tech start-ups, Ray also features a few trajectories of women TEs from humble beginnings, who did not study in the US and built alternative TE ventures.

5 | Limitations

Becoming Boundless puts migrants’ lives, decisions, and reflections at the center. The many excerpts from Ray’s interviews make the book lively and bring in TEs’ voices. However, several aspects of the book are less embedded in the literature and theoretical underpinnings. That is not to say that the book does not engage with theory. From the start it highlights social capital theory and intersectional approaches as key lenses. But apart from these macro approaches, the book would have benefitted from direct and thorough engagement with many aspects of migration and diaspora literature that speak to the various facets of the book’s narrative. Overall, the book’s strength lies in a thick description, leaving much of the theorization and its connection to existing scholarship to the reader. For example, there is limited incorporation of studies on migrant decision-making, or the New Economics of Labor Migration, which, as Ray does, emphasizes the role of households as the unit of decision-making. The book also does not engage with the literature on diaspora investment, which would have provided important precedents, questions, and insights into the decision-making process, the use of networks, and other aspects of diaspora and returnee entrepreneurship (see Graham 2013, 2019; Naujoks 2018, 2022; Riddle et al. 2010; Riddle and Brinkerhoff 2011).

Lastly, there are two limitations of the book that are common in sociological diaspora studies. First, the book focuses on the processes of decision-making, leaving the scale and impact out of the research’s remit. As studies on diaspora and return entrepreneurship mature, it is important to go beyond process questions to assessing the magnitude and effects of transnational entrepreneurship. Second, similar to studies on diaspora investment (Graham 2013, 2019; Naujoks and Kriaa 2016), scholarship on diasporic TEs would benefit from comparing diaspora with non-diaspora entrepreneurs.

Despite these limitations, *Becoming Boundless* is a great read, well researched, and a welcome contribution to our understanding of transnational entrepreneurship, transnational social spaces, diaspora engagement and return migration.

Conflicts of Interest

The author declares no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

Data sharing is not applicable.

Endnotes

¹ See Naujoks (2013, 2020) for details on the categorization and social meaning of OCI, as well as how OCI affects diaspora and returnee entrepreneurship.

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